

4. Is the functionalist committed to the view that an organization, like Sainsbury's, might have mental states? If so, is this a problem?

It would be generally accepted that Sainsbury's does not count as a 'mind', as minds are generally attributed to living biological beings. However functionalism defines the mind as simply anything that is functionally organised as one, with characteristics such as sensory inputs, behavioural outputs and some sort of processing or 'cognition' a typical mind would have. If an entity contains something that functions like a mind, then it has a mind.

In humans, the mind functions as the 'software' and the brain as the 'hardware', both of which control the behaviour of the body. Functionalism can see Sainsbury's as also having a mind, and therefore mind states appropriately analogous for the functional organisation and characteristics of a grocery store- for example rather than being 'hungry', Sainsbury's can 'act' or be functionally organised as 'hungry' if it has empty shelves. Sainsbury's also has inputs and outputs (stock, money), interacts with its' environment (suppliers, customers), and has executive managers which act as the 'cognitive' decision makers to make the store 'behave' in different ways (such as opening and closing, which can be analogous to sleeping).

Functionalism solves and embraces multiple realisability. It argues that it does not matter what physical 'hardware' a mind functions off of, whether it runs on silicon and electrons, or the managers and logistics of a supermarket. As long as the system has a correct functional organisation, with the right inputs linking to outputs, it is said to have a mind, and its state can be realised by any 'hardware'. Such systems can have constantly varying inputs and outputs, which can be described as varying behaviour, caused by their current state (of mind).

Therefore, if Sainsbury's acts like a mind and minds are subject to volatile mental states, then consequently Sainsbury's should also have mental states.

Assuming there is one true definition of a mind, functionalism tries to avoid the chauvinism of stricter approaches, such as identity theory which requires neurons and a brain, in order to not deny the existence of minds to those which may have one. Rather than attempting to set clear epistemology regarding minds and how they function, it simply states that if it acts like it has a mind, it does have one.

The problem with functionalism is it grants minds to entities which should not have one by defining what a mind is so liberally- it expands the definition further from the 'truth'. This makes the idea of what a mind is more abstract, and makes it harder to compare and find similarities between minds, as the differences become greater the more liberal the definition is. There are many more similarities between a human and even an alien mind than with a Sainsbury's mind, since at least both entities (assumably) are both living creatures with some sort of biological brain. Comparing a human mind to a Sainsbury's mind brings many more differences than similarities.

Block highlights functionalism's liberalism with a reductio ad absurdum. The population of China is roughly similar to the number of neurons in a human brain. If each Chinese person 'mimics' the functions of a neuron, then a functionalist should be committed to calling China a mind, since the country has similar organisational characteristics and functions of a mind.

This example sounds absurd and questions the general understanding of what a mind is- however, functionalism rightfully begs the question of where should the line be drawn in the definition of a mind. At what point should the line between a 'mind', and a corporate organisation, country, or supermarket, be drawn?

This is a key limitation of functionalism- somewhere on that line of abstraction, there is a divide where entities stop experiencing qualia which is a key feature of experience. Nagel argued that for an entity to have a conscious mind, there must be 'something it is like' to be that entity. Sainsbury's as a business may seem to loosely function like a mind, however there is no intuitive way to describe how an inanimate entity can 'feel' emotions or physical sensations, or 'how it feels to be Sainsbury's'.

This limitation is also an inseparable strength of this approach, as this is what allows it to accommodate multiple realisation. As a result functionalism is inherently committed to having a less strict definition of a mind so it can be realised in many ways, no matter how abstract.

Such an abstract understanding of the mind also spills into the general, 'folk' understanding of minds. A 'hive mind' is a general term used to colloquially describe a large collection of separate entities working and communicating together as a unit, often with shared inputs and outputs. This could include an organisation of bees in a hive, or an organised collection of over a billion Chinese people, theoretically working together to act like a mind. These 'hive minds' can be in varying states due to varying inputs, which would make them 'think' differently and produce different 'outputs', or behaviours.

While a collective swarm of bees is closer to a 'true' definition of a mind than an inanimate supermarket, functionalism treats them both the same. Functionalism strips away the necessity of subjective experience and qualia, and defining a mind purely by its functional organisation ignores the essence of consciousness. Ultimately the functionalist cannot draw principled boundaries in what is a mind and what is not, because the philosophy inherently forces liberalism due to the vague definition, so they are committed to viewing certain entities as minds, that most approaches would not.